

Women in the Ancient World

Set the biblical texts about women beside Athens, Rome, and Babylon, and something unexpected happens. The book so often accused of diminishing women keeps lifting them past their world. Not past every question. Past their world.

THE BASELINE

What the Ancient World Thought of Women

Before you can judge what the Bible says about women, you have to know what it was answering. Aristotle taught that the female is a kind of deformed male. Roman law placed a woman under the lifelong authority of a father or guardian. A surviving letter from a workman named Hilarion to his pregnant wife, written the year before Jesus was born, gives instructions for the coming birth. If it is a boy, keep it. If it is a girl, throw it out. He moves on to other business in the next line.

That was the air. In most Jewish courts a woman's testimony carried little or no weight. Pericles told the widows of Athens that their greatest glory was to be least spoken of among men, for praise or blame.

Lynn Cohick, who has studied the women of the earliest Christian centuries as carefully as anyone, warns against caricature. Real women ran businesses, owned property, led synagogues here and there. The ancient world was not a cartoon. But its floor was low and its ceiling was lower, and every biblical text about women entered that room, not ours. Reading them as if they were written to a modern democracy is the original mistake. Most of us made it before we knew it was one.

THE TORAH

An Image Shared From the First Page

Genesis 1:27 says God created humanity in his own image, male and female. No other creation account in the ancient Near East says anything like it. In Egypt and Mesopotamia, the image of god was royal vocabulary, reserved for the king, occasionally a priest, always a man at the top. Genesis hands the title to every field hand and every girl at the well. That is not a small adjustment to the ancient picture. It is a different picture.

The Torah's case law keeps the pattern. The daughters of Zelophehad walk into the most patriarchal scene imaginable, a tribal assembly dividing land, and ask for their dead father's inheritance, and God rules in

their favor. Captive women, the most disposable persons in ancient warfare, receive in Deuteronomy 21 mandated mourning time, marital status, and protection from being sold, while the surrounding nations' codes treat them as plunder with no rules at all.

Be honest about what this is. These laws regulate a hard world. They do not paint Eden. Paul Copan calls them incremental steps inside a fallen structure, pointing somewhere they do not yet arrive. A skeptic is right to notice the distance still to travel. The first readers would have noticed the direction.

THE GOSPELS

The Rabbi Who Kept Breaking the Rules

Luke 8 records, almost in passing, that Jesus traveled with women who funded the mission out of their own means. Named women. Traveling. Bankrolling a rabbi. There is no parallel for it among his contemporaries. When Mary of Bethany sits at his feet, she takes the recognized posture of a disciple before a teacher, the same phrase Paul uses of his own training under Gamaliel, and when Martha objects, Jesus says Mary has chosen the better part and it will not be taken from her.

He teaches theology to a Samaritan woman at a well, the longest recorded conversation he has with anyone in John's Gospel, and she becomes the first preacher to her town. He lets the bleeding woman everyone called unclean touch him, and calls her daughter. He calls a bent-over woman a daughter of Abraham, an honor formula with no surviving parallel before him.

And then the resurrection. Every Gospel names women as the first witnesses, in a world where their testimony was discounted in court. The pagan critic Celsus later sneered at a faith resting on the word of a hysterical female. No one inventing a respectable story would have written it this way. They wrote it this way because they were willing to be laughed at for what they saw.

THE LETTERS

Read the Names in Romans Sixteen

The last chapter of Romans reads like a church directory, and a third of the names are women. Phoebe, a deacon of the church at Cenchreae, carries the letter itself, which in the ancient world meant she likely read it aloud and answered questions about it, making her the first public expositor of Romans. Priscilla, named before her husband more often than not, takes the brilliant preacher Apollos aside and corrects his theology. Junia is called outstanding among the apostles, and for centuries some copyists and translators quietly turned her into a man named Junias, a name that does not otherwise exist in the ancient record, because they could not believe the sentence they were reading. The manuscripts have her name. The church flinched at it.

House churches met in the homes of Lydia, Nympha, Mary of Jerusalem, and Chloe, and in that world the host of a gathering was never a bystander to it. Richard Bauckham and Lynn Cohick have traced these

women from the margins of our attention back to the center of the earliest churches' life. They were not a footnote. We made them one.

HONEST WEIGHTS

What This Does Not Settle

Now the honesty this site owes you. None of this dissolves every hard text. 1 Timothy 2 and 1 Corinthians 14 are still in the book, and serious readers who love both Scripture and the women in their churches divide over what those passages required then and require now. Some conclude every office is open to women. Some conclude the office of elder is ordered differently. Both camps include scholars of the first rank and churches full of grace. That debate deserves its own fair hearing, with each position at full strength, and we try to give it one elsewhere on this site. This guide will not settle it by ambush, and you should distrust any guide that tries.

This guide has a smaller claim, and it holds. Measured against its own world, the biblical record keeps moving in one direction, toward the daughters of Zelophehad, the women at the tomb, the deacon carrying Romans.

The church has not always moved with it. Texts written into a hard world to protect women have been quoted to demean them, and I have sat in rooms where it happened and said nothing. The book was ahead of its world. Its readers are not always ahead of theirs.

KEY TEXTS

Genesis 1:27

Luke 8:1-3

Romans 16:1-7

SOURCES

Women in the World of the Earliest Christians — Lynn H. Cohick

Gospel Women: Studies of the Named Women in the Gospels — Richard Bauckham

Is God a Moral Monster? Making Sense of the Old Testament God — Paul Copan

Women in the Ministry of Jesus — Ben Witherington III